

SPEAKING WITH THE DEAD

spiritualism

From the mid-19th century onward, the practice of spiritualism became a craze across Europe and America. The key idea, based on the mainstream Christian belief in an afterlife, was that people who had died inhabited a “spirit world” and the living could communicate with them, typically through a facilitator called a medium. A major reason for the popularity of spiritualism was that it offered a consoling chance for the bereaved to communicate with lost loved ones.

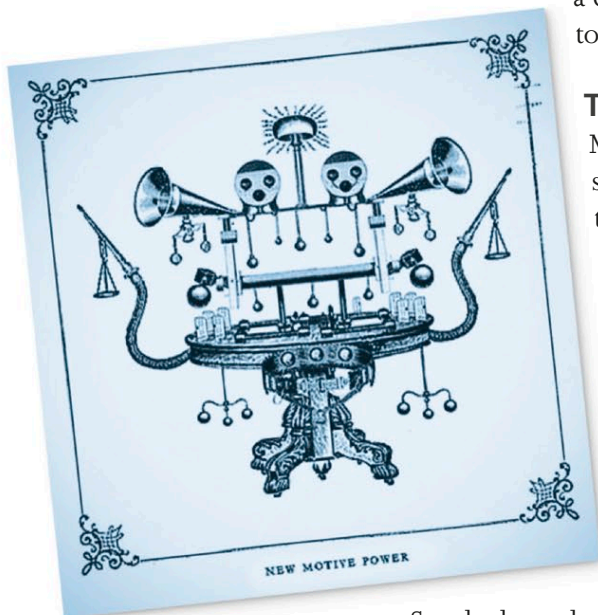
The Witch of Endor

Many ideas prompted the rise of spiritualism. One was the biblical tale about the Witch of Endor, a sorceress who summoned the spirit of the prophet Samuel for King Saul. Her name became a byword for raising spirits from the dead. The ideas of many influential Enlightenment-era thinkers and, later, Romantics also fed into spiritualism. In his 1758 book *Heaven and Hell*, the Swedish mystic and scientist Emanuel

Swedenborg dealt with life after death and communing with the spirit world, while German physician Franz Anton Mesmer (see pp.210–213) promoted trance states linked with channeling and transmitting powerful forces.

A sensational start

Modern spiritualism is often said to have started in upstate New York in 1848 with two sisters, Maggie and Kate Fox, who, it was claimed, could commune with the dead. Spirit beings apparently made eerie rapping noises in response to questions posed by the girls in their humble home. Aided by their elder sister, Leah, the Fox sisters soon acquired great fame as the first major mediums of modern spiritualism, convincing many of their authenticity. They were much imitated in the middle-class parlors of



▲ Brave new world?

Mid-century spiritualist ideas included J.M. Spear's New Motive Power machine of 1854, shown here in an etching. With a table and magnetized balls, this electrical machine was intended to connect humans to God: the plan was that it would be animated by a spirit.

